

THIS IS TECHNOLOGY, CULTURE AND SCIENCE WITH A DIFFERENCE, AND THAT DIFFERENCE IS USUALLY ENOUGH TO MAKE MOST NORMAL PEOPLE GO "WTF?"

ALT this month:

Learn more about the infrastructure and security in GST, the AI in LG products, and Netmeds in this month's Backtalk. Then take a look at examples of Albinism and Melanism in animals in 1000 Words. Then, in Geek-key, celebrate 80 years of the caped crusader – Batman.



What Anthropocene?

The Anthropocene is a proposed geological epoch where the activities of humans are a significant force in the shaping of the world around us. However, on geological time scales, our entire history is merely a blip, starting between 400 to 75 years ago. Other epochs have lasted 400 million years. The very idea feels like a joke.

<https://dgit.in/anthjk>

WHAT'S NEW

The saga of the null license plate

A security researcher (read hacker), Joseph Tartaro wanting to get a vanity license plate that had something to do with his profession, decided to go for a plate that said "null". The researcher thought that the system would be fooled by the value, and prevent any tickets for traffic violations being sent his way. He ended up hacking himself in the process, causing more trouble than he anticipated. He ended up with over \$12,000 of fines, which were because of violations from vehicles that he did not own, or in places he had never visited. Every time a policeman forgot to enter the details of the vehicle, the citation was routed to Tartaro. His mailbox started getting flooded with citations



from all across the state, and when he contacted the authorities, he found that there was no way to fix it. Either he could pay

up the fines, or laboriously prove that he was not the person who violated the rules for every single citation. Irregularities started appearing in the records, with his vehicle make and model being entered in violations, even when the original citations had a different vehicle. The citations continue to pile on.

<https://dgit.in/nullplate>

How microbes influence your social life

A unique mix of microbes live within every animal, and this is known as the microbiome. The guts of humans contain a particularly rich variety of microbes. Microbiomes exist within other primate species as well. For a long time, scientists believed that the specific composition of the microbiome was because of diet and environment. Researchers studying the behavior of primates found a surprising link between social behavior and the micro-



biome. The research suggests that there is a deep relation between microbes and social interactions, with each influencing the other. Every slap, pat on the back, scratch, kiss and sneeze is part of a story, one that

drives our social interactions, and might be beneficial to humans in unexpected ways. We know that the microbiomes are surprisingly diverse, and they aid in digestion, boost immunity, produce vitamins, and prevent the growth of harmful bacteria. There may be other benefits of the microbiome that we do not yet know of. The finding provides some insight into why humans became social animals in the first place.

<https://dgit.in/mbsapiens>



Making baldness obsolete

So far, balding has been an almost insurmountable problem. There is good news for bald people around the world. A global shortfall in hair will no longer be a problem because of new techniques that combine innovative uses of stem cells with 3D printing.

<https://dgit.in/3dhair>



Fake Facebook accounts

Facebook does not seem to be growing, and has practically run out of new people to bring onto the platform. Yet advertisers are still being promised more reach, at times exceeding the populations in certain areas. Is Facebook just a massive fraud riding on the backs of fake accounts?

<https://dgit.in/ponzifb>



The tyranny of productivity

One of the most universally understood sentiments is that work sucks. This is why most people hate Mondays so much. What is the cause of this resentment, and can it be fixed? Modern capitalism puts productivity ahead of human experience, which may be counterproductive.

<https://dgit.in/tyrprod>